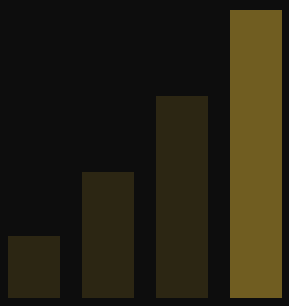
P2SEC

2027 EDITION · FREE GUIDE

The 2027 Cyber Cert Roadmap

Four certifications you can actually hold in your first year, in the order that works, and the honest timeline for the senior ones.



Written by a working cybersecurity professional

Whose day job is auditing identity and access controls against NIST SP 800-63

Every cert fact verified 13 November 2026 against official certifying-body pages

Built for career changers and absolute beginners

START HERE

The 30-second version.

Four certifications, in one fixed order, then a job. Not twelve certifications. The list is filtered on one question only: **can a beginner with no security job actually hold this in year one?** Everything else waits.

STEP 1 · THE ANCHOR

Security+

SY0-801 (V8). No experience gate. Do not start a second cert before this one is passed.

STEP 2 · CLOUD BASICS

AWS CLF-C02

Cloud Practitioner. The cheapest way to stop being illiterate in the platform security work now runs on.

STEP 3 · CLOUD DEPTH

AWS SAA-C03

Solutions Architect Associate. The exam that makes you design, not just name services.

STEP 4 · IDENTITY

Microsoft SC-300

Go direct. No prerequisite, and SC-900 would only repeat what Security+ already proved.

THEN, AND ONLY THEN · GET THE JOB

The first-year goal is not a certification wall. It is one job: **SOC analyst, IT support, or GRC analyst**. Those are the roles the certifying bodies themselves name as targets, and none of them is guaranteed by any certificate. A cert qualifies you to apply. Work experience is what unlocks everything on page 09.

THE YEAR-ONE SEQUENCE, IN ORDER

01 Security+ SY0-801

02 AWS CLF-C02

03 AWS SAA-C03

04 Microsoft SC-300

05 Get a job: SOC / IT support / GRC analyst

Optional step zero: Network+ (N10-009), only if networking is completely foreign to you. It is not in the four because it delays the anchor.

RESEARCHED AND KEPT OUT OF 2027

SecAI+ (cut) · GRCP (cut) · GRCA (cut) · CGRC (cut) · SC-900 (skip) · PenTest+ · SecurityX · SCS-C03 · Okta Administrator · SailPoint · CIDPRO · CISSP / CISM

Each one is on page 07 or 08 with the reason. "Cut" means researched and rejected, not overlooked.

HOW TO READ THE LABELS IN THIS GUIDE

FACT exam code, length, passing score, fee, experience rule, renewal. Read from the certifying body's own page, verified 13 November 2026. RECOMMENDATION the order, the timing, when to book. That is judgement, not fact. FLAGGED the figure is secondary-only and was not on an official page. Do not budget on it.

NO JOB PROMISES

A certification qualifies you to apply against the body's own stated roles. It does not hire you.

NO SALARY CLAIMS

Pay depends on market, role and location. No badge controls that.

NO VENDOR SPONSORSHIP

Every cert is judged on gate, cost and return in year one. Cut means cut.

STEP 1 · EVERYONE STARTS HERE

CompTIA Security+

The one certification that appears as a baseline requirement across defensive, offensive, cloud and identity job postings. It is the only cert on this roadmap with no experience gate and universal recognition.

FACT Verified 13 November 2026

CURRENT EXAM	SY0-801 (V8)
LAUNCH	On or around 17 November 2026
PREVIOUS EXAM	SY0-701 (launched 7 Nov 2023), English retires 11 June 2027
QUESTIONS	Maximum 90, multiple choice and performance based
DURATION	90 minutes
PASSING SCORE	750 on a scale of 100 to 900
FORMAL PREREQUISITE	None listed by CompTIA
RECOMMENDED	About two years hands on as a security administrator
VALIDITY	Three years from the date earned
RENEWAL	CompTIA continuing education, or a qualifying higher-level cert
EXAM FEE	Not published on the cert page; secondary list 439 USD FLAGGED

COMPTIA'S OWN TARGET ROLES

- Security Analyst
- Security Engineer
- Systems Administrator

WHAT IT DOES NOT DO

It does not, by itself, qualify anyone for a SOC analyst, penetration tester or architect job. Those need the experience plus hands-on work. Security+ is DoD 8140 approved, and that is the only official job signal attached to it.

V8 DOMAINS

Security Operations	27%
Threats, Vulnerabilities, Attacks	24%
Security Architecture	19%
General Security Concepts	16%
Program Mgmt (incl. AI risks)	14%

Which version to sit

Recommendation: study V8 (SY0-801) from day one. The English SY0-701 retires 11 June 2027, so anyone testing after that date has no choice. Learning the V8 objectives once beats switching versions mid-prep. The one new thing in V8 is a single objective on the security risks associated with AI, not a whole domain.

Study time to plan for

8 to 12 weeks at 8 to 10 hours a week if security is new to you. Faster if you already work in IT and only need the vocabulary and the exam format. Read the official objectives, not just a course: the objectives are the exam.

THE VERSION DEADLINE, IN PRACTICE

SY0-801 and SY0-701 are the **same certification**: three-year validity, same CE renewal, no version printed on the badge that employers check. There is no advantage to rushing SY0-701 before it retires in June 2027, and no penalty for sitting SY0-801 after it launches. Study whichever objectives you can book against, and treat V8 as the default from launch day.

THE REST OF YEAR ONE

Three certs after Security+.

None of these three has a prerequisite. That is exactly why they are on the list and the others are not: passing them certifies you, with no job required and no vendor gate to get in.

FACT AWS and Microsoft pages, opened 13 November 2026

CERTIFICATION	FEE	FORMAT	PASS MARK	VALIDITY	GATE TO SIT
AWS Cloud Practitioner CLF-C02	100 USD	65 questions 90 minutes	700 / 1000	3 years	None. Up to six months of AWS exposure is suggested and explicitly not required.
AWS Solutions Architect – Associate SAA-C03	150 USD	65 questions 130 minutes	720 / 1000	3 years	None. AWS recommends one or more years designing on AWS.
Microsoft Identity and Access Administrator SC-300	165 USD varies by region	Microsoft exam in person or online	700 / 1000	1 year, free online renewal	None. Microsoft lists familiarity with Azure, Microsoft 365, AD DS, PowerShell and KQL, not a prerequisite cert.

Why cloud before identity

Every SOC, GRC and identity role now touches a cloud console. CLF-C02 is the cheapest exam on this roadmap at 100 USD and the fastest to pass. SAA-C03 costs more and takes longer, but it is the one that changes what you can be trusted to do, because it makes you design instead of name services. SAA-C03 is about 30 percent security content: it is an architecture cert, not a security cert, and that is the point.

Why SC-300 last, and direct

SC-900 is not required before SC-300. Microsoft lists no prerequisite for either. After Security+, SC-900 is largely duplicative: broad security, compliance and identity concepts you have just been tested on. Go straight to SC-300. It is the strongest single IAM credential if your target employers run Microsoft 365 and Entra.

BUDGET FOR THE FOUR · IN THE OPEN

Security+ at a secondary list price of 439 USD, plus 100 + 150 + 165 for the other three, is about **854 USD** at list, before any voucher or bundle. The AWS 50 percent voucher is real but only partly verified (page 05), so do not plan around it. Prices change: re-check at checkout on each body's own store before you book.

RECOMMENDATION · STUDY LOAD FOR EACH, AT 8 TO 10 HOURS A WEEK

4 to 6 weeks
AWS CLF-C02
Mostly vocabulary, billing and the support model. If you have never opened the AWS console, spend one week hands-on before you start reading.

8 to 12 weeks
AWS SAA-C03
The heaviest of the four. Expect design trade-off questions, not recall. Build one small architecture per week or the exam reads as trivia.

6 to 10 weeks
Microsoft SC-300
Entra ID, hybrid identity and governance. Comfort with PowerShell and KQL shortens this materially; a free tenant shortens it more.

STEPS 2 AND 3 · THE CLOUD

Cloud, and the voucher myth.

Cloud is the highest-paid of the entry paths and the one where a certification moves a resume fastest, because the work is tied to one specific platform. Pick one cloud and go deep.

FACT All AWS certifications: no prerequisite, valid 3 years, no annual fee

AWS CERTIFICATION	LEVEL	FEE	FORMAT	RECOMMENDED EXPERIENCE, AND WHY IT IS HERE OR NOT
Cloud Practitioner CLF-C02	Foundational	100 USD	65 q / 90 min	Up to six months of exposure, not required. Foundational vocabulary only. Does not qualify for a cloud or security job alone. YEAR 1
Solutions Architect – Associate SAA-C03	Associate	150 USD	65 q / 130 min	One or more years designing on AWS. About 30% security content. It is an architecture cert, not a security cert. YEAR 1
Security – Specialty SCS-C03	Specialty	300 USD	65 q / 170 min	Disputed: three to five years securing cloud solutions, or five years of IT security plus two on AWS. UNRESOLVED See page 07. LATER

SCS-C03 launched 2 December 2025, replacing SCS-C02, which retired 1 December 2025. A specialty is parallel to Professional level, not above Associate in the hierarchy.

THE 50 PERCENT VOUCHER: WHAT IS VERIFIED, AND WHAT IS NOT

VERIFIED ON AN OFFICIAL AWS PAGE

- A 50 percent discount voucher exists. The AWS Benefits page says you get one to apply toward recertification or any other exam.
- Benefits appear in your AWS Certification Account, within five business days of passing.

NOT VERIFIED ON ANY OFFICIAL PAGE

- That each pass earns a **new** voucher.
- That the voucher lasts **one year**.
- The single-use terms, and that expiry cannot be extended.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR BUDGET

Plan as if the voucher exists, is single-use, and shows an expiry in your own account. **The certain cost at list price is 550 USD** for CLF-C02, SAA-C03 and SCS-C03 together. **The maximum saving is 225 USD** if the chain works exactly as the unverified guides describe. Budget 550 USD. Treat the 225 USD as a maybe, never as a guarantee.

Do the math on year one

CLF-C02 plus SAA-C03 is **250 USD** at list. That is the whole cloud spend for 2027. SCS-C03 is a 2028 or later purchase, after you are working in a cloud.

One cloud, not three

Employers hire for the platform they run. Learning a second cloud's concepts is cheap and worth doing later. Paying for a second cloud's certification before you have a cloud job is not.

STEP 4 · THE IDENTITY PATH

Identity has one real shortcut.

Identity is the quiet track: less competition, central to zero trust, and it rewards people who like process, data and access reviews. It also has the most traps, so read the gates before you buy anything.

Microsoft SC-300 — 165 USD

The one to take. No prerequisite. Audience familiarity is listed as Azure, Microsoft 365 workloads, Active Directory Domain Services, PowerShell and KQL, none of which is a gate to sitting the exam. Pass mark 700 of 1000. Valid 1 year, renewed by a free online assessment.

RECOMMENDATION

Take it directly after Security+. Skip SC-900: Microsoft lists no prerequisite for either, and after Security+ the SC-900 content is largely duplicative.

Okta Certified Professional — 250 USD

Holdable, if you can get hands on Okta. No prerequisite. 15 discrete-option multiple-choice questions plus 4 performance use cases, 150 minutes. Recommended: one year in a technical security or identity role plus three months hands-on Okta. Valid two years.

RECOMMENDATION

Only if your target employers name Okta. Both Okta exams are hands-on in a live Okta org, so without about three months of Okta access through a job, lab or tenant, this is not a realistic first cert.

SailPoint Administrator / Engineer — LATER

No prerequisite, but employer gated. The official Policy Handbook lists the prerequisite as None for both certs, with a two-year validity. Both still recommend six to twelve months of hands-on product time.

RECOMMENDATION

Exams are purchasable only inside Identity University, which is gated, and preparation needs a product tenant. A beginner with no job cannot meaningfully prepare. Revisit once you are inside an IAM team.

IDPro CIDPRO — 750 USD

Holdable, poor return. No prerequisite and no experience requirement stated on the official FAQ. About 150 questions, 3 hours, online proctored. No validity period and no continuing education stated at this time.

RECOMMENDATION

Poor value in 2027 against SC-300 at 165 USD or Okta Professional at 250 USD. A later purchase for someone already in an identity program role, not a first credential.

THE ONE HARD CHAIN IN IDENTITY

Okta Professional is a prerequisite for Okta Certified Administrator. Okta's own prep guide states it plainly: an active Professional certification is required, and it must be active at registration. Administrator is 250 USD, valid two years.

Okta lists Professional as the prerequisite for Administrator, Consultant and Architect. There is no side door.

If you can only pick one

Pick **SC-300**. It is the most common IAM requirement in job posts, the cheapest of the four, and it has no gate. Okta and SailPoint are platform credentials: worth more when the job posting names the platform, worth little as a generic badge.

Identity is also where the GRC track overlaps: access reviews, joiner-mover-leaver evidence and role design are the same work seen from the auditor's side.

NOT WRONG, JUST EARLY

Later, not never.

Every cert below is real, and every one has no experience gate to hold. They are off the 2027 list for a different reason: the recommended experience describes work you do not have yet, so the return in year one is poor.

CERTIFICATION	FEE	RECOMMENDED EXPERIENCE	STATUS	WHY IT WAITS
CompTIA CySA+ CS0-004 (V4), launched 23 Jun 2026	439 secondary FLAGGED	About four years as a SOC or vulnerability analyst	LATER	Builds on Security+, not a repeat: security operations 34%, vulnerability management 26%, incident response 24%, reporting 16%. Do it as your first cert **inside** a SOC job.
CompTIA PenTest+ PT0-003 (V3)	439 secondary FLAGGED	Three to four years as a penetration tester, with Network+ and Security+ knowledge	LATER	Offensive work is a second job, not a first one. Do not take CySA+ and PenTest+ back to back with no job: pick defence or offence.
CompTIA SecurityX CAS-005 (V5), formerly CASP+	Not found FLAGGED	Ten years of IT, including five in security	LATER	Senior capstone, pass or fail with no scaled score. A five-year horizon item, not a 2027 target.
AWS Security – Specialty SCS-C03	300	Disputed: 3 to 5 years securing cloud, or 5 years IT security plus 2 on AWS	LATER	Not straight after CLF-C02 with no security or AWS work. Do SAA-C03 first; this becomes readable once you design in AWS daily.
Okta Certified Administrator OKADM1	250	About two years in role and one year with Okta SECONDARY	CHAINED	Requires an active Okta Certified Professional first. Not a 2027 purchase. See page 06.
SailPoint Identity Security Administrator / IdentityIQ Engineer	Not in handbook FLAGGED	Six to twelve months hands on the product	GATED	Prerequisite is officially None, but the exams are only purchasable inside Identity University and preparation needs a tenant. Employer gated in practice.
IDPro CIDPRO	750	None stated on the official FAQ	LATER	No job gate and no continuing education, at three times the price of SC-300. Poor return until you are in an identity program role.

THE RULE BEHIND THIS PAGE

Pass equals certified is not the same as ready. None of these has an experience gate, so technically you can sit any of them next month. The recommended experience is the body telling you what the exam assumes, and paying 300 to 750 USD to sit an exam whose vocabulary you have never used at work is the most common way beginners waste a year.

ON THE RECORD

Five that were cut, and why.

These were in earlier drafts of this roadmap. They are listed here so the cut is documented, not quietly deleted: each one was researched against its certifying body and rejected for a stated reason.

CompTIA SecAI+ (CY0-001)

CUT

Not a duplicate, but premature. 40 percent of the exam is securing AI systems: prompt injection, jailbreaks, model extraction, training data poisoning, adversarial ML. None of that is in Security+. The other 60 percent re-applies known Security+ topics through an AI lens. CompTIA calls it an expansion cert and its FAQ says it is not for people entering cybersecurity for the first time. It assumes Security+ or CySA+ level knowledge and two or more years of work.

Revisit after two years of cybersecurity work, or in an AI-facing role. Employers will not credit an AI specialism without a security foundation and a job. The 2027 priority is CySA+ inside a SOC, or getting the job first.

OCEG GRCP and GRCA

CUT

Largely redundant for the goal that matters. They teach OCEG's GRC Capability Model, which is not ISACA's or ISC2's body of knowledge, and they earn no waiver or experience credit toward CISA, CISM or CISSP. No experience gate, open book, 100 questions, 120 minutes, 70 percent to pass, bundled into the 499 USD a year All Access Pass.

Verdict: useful study material for GRC vocabulary, weak as a credential. The vocabulary can come from the labs and the work itself. Do not present either as progress toward CISA, CISM or CISSP.

ISC2 CGRC

CUT

Not redundant in content, but narrow and gated. 599 USD exam plus 135 USD a year maintenance, 125 questions, 3 hours, 700 of 1000. Holding it needs two years of cumulative full-time work in one of the seven domains, with no degree waiver published. Its core is system authorisation and RMF, valuable mainly in federal, defence or RMF roles.

Status of the CISSP waiver: CGRC is reported to waive one year of CISSP, from the ISC2 approved credential list revised 1 April 2026. That list was not opened live in this research, so treat the waiver as reported, not verified. Not a reason to buy it.

Microsoft SC-900

SKIP

Duplicative after Security+. Microsoft lists no prerequisite for SC-900 or SC-300, so nothing is unlocked by taking SC-900 first. It runs 45 minutes at a 700 pass mark and covers broad security, compliance and identity concepts that Security+ has just tested harder. OFFICIAL PAGE NOT OPENED LIVE Its 99 USD fee and no-expiry status come from the Microsoft price table as reported by secondary sources.

It is useful only as a cheap Microsoft-specific vocabulary check. If you already hold Security+, put the money toward SC-300.

WHAT REPLACED ALL FIVE

Nothing. That is the point. The route to a well-paid GRC or audit role does not run through a pile of GRC certificates: it runs through work, then CISA, CISM or CISSP. None of the five above shortens that, and none waives ISACA or ISC2 experience.

THE HONEST CLOCK

CISA, CISM, CISSP: years, not months.

This is where most roadmaps lie. All three exams can be sat early. None can be **held** without real work experience, and none is a 2027 goal for someone starting from zero. The clock below is work years, not study years.

GOAL	FEE (US)	WORK REQUIRED TO HOLD IT	EARLIEST, IF A RELEVANT JOB STARTS IN 2027
ISACA CISA	575 member / 760 non-member, plus 50 application, plus 45 or 85 a year	5 years of IS audit, control, assurance or security work in the last 10 years, minimum 2 of them direct in a CISA domain. Waivers capped at 3 years. A bachelor's in **any field** counts 2 years; a master's in Information Systems counts 3.	**About 2030**, at 3 years of work. About 2029 with a master's in IS. With no waiver at all: 2032.
ISC2 CISSP	749 in the Americas, plus 135 a year AMF	5 years cumulative paid work in at least 2 of the 8 domains. Only 1 year can be waived, by a degree in computer science or IT on the official page, or by an approved credential such as Security+. Not both.	**About 2031**, at 4 years of work with the one-year waiver. About 2032 at 5 years if no waiver applies.
ISACA CISM	575 member / 760 non-member, plus 50 application, plus 45 or 85 a year	5 years of information security **management** experience, with at least 3 years in 3 of the 4 domains, and that part cannot be waived. Waivers capped at 2 years. A generic bachelor's waives **0** years for CISM; Security+ waives 1.	**Realistically 2032**: 5 years, or 4 with Security+. Only if you are managing people or a programme from about 2027.

CISM IS NOT A THREE-YEARS-FROM-ZERO CERT

Management experience is the gate, not just years served. Do CISA first, then CISM only after you manage people or a security programme. Do not schedule CISM before that, and do not take CISA and CISM as a pair in the same year.

SITTING EARLY, AND THE EXPIRY TRAP

You may sit any of the three before you meet the experience requirement, but a pass banked in 2027 has to become a certification application within five years (ISACA), or become full CISSP within six years as an Associate of ISC2. With no job lined up, the pass can lapse before the experience is earned.

SEQUENCING THAT FOLLOWS FROM THE EVIDENCE · A RECOMMENDATION, NOT A PROMISE OF EMPLOYMENT

2027	Security+ SY0-801, then CLF-C02, then SAA-C03, then SC-300. Then get any SOC, IT support or GRC analyst job. **No GRCP:** the GRC vocabulary comes from the labs and the work itself.
2027–29	Work in audit, GRC or RMF as it is available. Sit the CISA exam when ready, because a pass is banked for five years. **No CGRC on the way:** go straight for CISA.
ca. 2030	CISA, at three years of work with the bachelor's waiver.
2030–31	CISSP exam, then Associate of ISC2, then full CISSP at four years of work.
2032+	CISM, once you hold three years of management experience. Not before.

PUT IT IN A CALENDAR

A 12-month plan for 2027.

A recommendation, not a rule. It assumes roughly 10 hours a week. Move the dates; keep the order.

Q1 2027

Security+

Sit SY0-801 by the end of March. Study V8 objectives from day one. Do not start a second cert before this one is passed.

Q2 2027

AWS CLF-C02

100 USD, the shortest exam on the list. Book it before you feel ready. Pass mark 700 of 1000.

Q3 2027

AWS SAA-C03

The hard one. 130 minutes and real design questions. This is the cert that changes what you can be trusted to do.

Q4 2027

Microsoft SC-300

Direct, no SC-900. Then job applications in earnest: SOC Tier 1, IT support, GRC analyst.

ALL YEAR · TWO LAB PROJECTS, DOCUMENTED

One detection or incident writeup. One cloud, identity or control-mapping build. Certifications get you the interview; the writeups get you the offer. If you cannot explain what you built and why, it does not count.

If you have zero IT experience

Get any technical job first: help desk, desktop support, or a network operations center role, and take it while you study. The certification will not compensate for having never worked a ticket, and the ticket job is what gives you the stories you will tell in interviews.

If you already work in IT

Skip the foundational certs and go straight at Security+. Then pick cloud or identity based on the team you want to transfer into. Internal moves are the least competitive route into security, and your current manager is the cheapest sponsor you will ever find.

FIVE RULES THAT DECIDE WHETHER THIS WORKS

1. **One certification at a time.** Starting three is how people finish none.
2. **Book the exam date before you feel ready.** A date creates urgency a study plan cannot.
3. **Lab everything you read.** If you cannot show it, you do not know it.
4. **Read the official objectives, not just a course.** The objectives are the exam.
5. **Budget for renewal.** Every CompTIA cert here expires in three years; SC-300 renews every 12 months.

WHAT NOT TO DO IN 2027

SecAI+ · GRCP · GRCA · CGRC · SC-900 · PenTest+ · SecurityX · AWS SCS-C03 · Okta Administrator · SailPoint · CIDPRO at 750 · CISSP or CISM as a goal

Every item above is on page 07 or 08 with the reason it waits. "Cut" means researched and rejected. "Skip" means duplicative. "Later" means pass-equals-certified but the return in year one is poor.

REFERENCE

Facts at a glance.

Every code, fee, gate and renewal rule below was read from the certifying body's own page on 13 November 2026. Where an official price was not published, or was only available from a secondary source, the table says so instead of guessing.

CERTIFICATION	EXAM CODE	FEE (USD)	VALIDITY AND RENEWAL	STATUS
COMPTIA				
Security+	SY0-801 (V8)	Not on cert page; 439 secondary	3 years, CE or higher cert	YEAR 1
CySA+	CS0-004 (V4)	Not on cert page; 439 secondary	3 years, CE or higher cert	LATER
PenTest+	PT0-003 (V3)	Not on cert page; 439 secondary	3 years, CE or higher cert	LATER
SecAI+	CY0-001 (V1)	Not on cert page; 298 secondary	3 years, 15 CEUs	CUT
SecurityX (formerly CASP+)	CAS-005 (V5)	Not found	3 years, CE or higher cert	LATER
AMAZON WEB SERVICES · NO PREREQUISITES, 3-YEAR VALIDITY, NO ANNUAL FEE				
Cloud Practitioner	CLF-C02	100	3 years, recertify by exam	YEAR 1
Solutions Architect – Associate	SAA-C03	150	3 years, recertify by exam	YEAR 1
Security – Specialty	SCS-C03	300	3 years, recertify by exam	LATER
IDENTITY AND ACCESS MANAGEMENT				
Microsoft Identity and Access Administrator	SC-300	165, varies by region	1 year, free online renewal	YEAR 1
Microsoft Security, Compliance and Identity Fundamentals	SC-900	99 secondary FLAGGED	No expiry (secondary)	SKIP
Okta Certified Professional	OKPRO1	250 first attempt, 100 retake	2 years	OPTIONAL
Okta Certified Administrator	OKADM1	250, 100 retake	2 years; Professional required first	CHAINED
SailPoint Identity Security Administrator	SailPoint program	Not in handbook	2 years; Identity University only	GATED
SailPoint IdentityIQ Engineer	SailPoint program	Not in handbook	2 years; Identity University only	GATED
CIDPRO (IDPro)	IDPro program	750	None stated on the FAQ	LATER
GOVERNANCE, RISK AND COMPLIANCE				
OCEG GRCP / GRCA	OCEG program	Included in 499/yr All Access Pass	Active pass, 8 CPE a year	CUT
ISC2 CGRC	ISC2 program	599 exam + 135/yr AMF	60 CPE over 3 years	CUT
ISACA CISA	ISACA program	575 member / 760 non-member + 50	20 CPE/yr; 45 or 85 a year	GATED
ISACA CISM	ISACA program	575 member / 760 non-member + 50	20 CPE/yr; 45 or 85 a year	GATED
ISC2 CISSP	ISC2 program	749 Americas + 135/yr AMF	CPE + 135 a year (50 as Associate)	GATED

ON COMPTIA PRICING

CompTIA does not publish a single list price on its certification pages, and voucher prices vary with bundles, retakes and region. Budget a few hundred US dollars per attempt and confirm the number at checkout on comptia.org. Academic pricing, exam bundles and employer reimbursement are the three legitimate ways to reduce it.

WHAT THIS GUIDE LEAVES OUT

Course-based certificates and badge-style credentials are not what hiring managers screen on for the roles in this guide.

SOURCES USED FOR VERIFICATION

comptia.org: Security+ V8 and V7, CySA+ V4, PenTest+ V3, SecAI+ V1, SecurityX, CE
aws.amazon.com: certification benefits, CLF-C02, SAA-C03, SCS-C03
learn.microsoft.com: SC-300, SC-900
okta.com and certification.okta.com: program and prep guides
community.sailpoint.com: Policy Handbook
idpro.org: CIDPRO FAQ · oceg.org: GRCP, GRCA, membership
isaca.org and support.isaca.org: CISA, CISM requirements
isc2.org: CISSP and CGRC experience requirements
csrc.nist.gov: SP 800-63-4 (final, July 2025)

THE HONESTY PAGE

Open questions.

A figure that is not on an official page stays flagged here rather than being promoted into the roadmap as fact. Nothing on the previous pages depends on an item below.

Still not verified

- **AWS 50% voucher duration and per-pass renewal.** Not on the official Benefits page. Third-party guides assert one year and a new voucher per pass; two careful reviews of the AWS pages say they do not state it.
- **AWS SCS-C03 recommended experience.** Three to five years securing cloud, against five years IT security plus two on AWS. Both sources cite AWS. Unresolved.
- **CompTIA exam prices.** 439 and 298 were not read live on the CompTIA store. SecAI+ appeared at 359 in some 2026 sources and 298 in October 2026. No SecurityX price was found at all.
- **SailPoint exam fees.** Not in the official Policy Handbook, because Identity University is gated. Secondary figures conflict.
- **CISSP degree waiver for a non-IT degree.** The ISC2 page says computer science, IT or related fields; secondary guides say any field. Do not assume the waiver.

Verified but caveated

- **CISA bachelor's waiver field.** The ISACA Support page says any field, worth 2 years. Some secondary sources say IT or accounting only. Follow the Support page and re-check the live application before counting on it.
- **Okta Administrator recommended experience.** About two years in role and one year with Okta. Secondary only; the official Administrator study guide was not opened live.
- **SC-900 fee and no-expiry status.** From the Microsoft price table as reported by secondary sources, not a live open of the SC-900 Learn page.
- **CIDPRO experience and validity.** The official FAQ states neither. The claims of two or more years of experience, and of no expiry, are secondary only.
- **CGRC waiving one year of CISSP, and the GRCA-before-GRCP rule.** Both are reported from secondary or conflicting official pages. CGRC is cut either way.

WHAT A CERTIFICATION DOES AND DOES NOT DO

No certifying body guarantees a job or a role. Every role mapping in this guide is the body's own stated target role, not an employment promise. A certification qualifies you to apply against the body's stated targets. The job comes from the work, the lab writeups and the interview.

DISCLAIMER

Exam versions, prices, prerequisites and renewal rules change without notice. Everything in this guide is accurate as of 13 November 2026. Prices are US list. Confirm on the certifying body's own site before you spend money or book a date.

Research method: every exam code, question count, duration, passing score, fee, experience gate and renewal rule in this guide was checked against the certifying body's own pages in November 2026. Where a figure was only available from a secondary source, it is marked FLAGGED and it is not used in any recommendation.